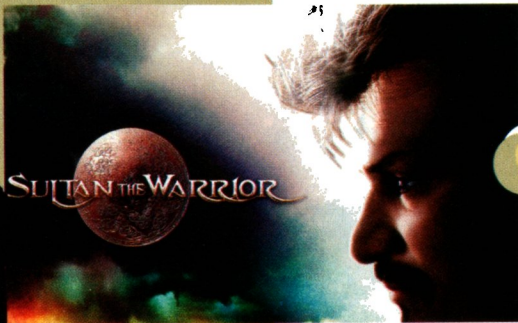




FILM: *Sultan the Warrior*
PRODUCER: Ocher and Adlabs
COST: Rs 40 crore **USP:** Has Rajnikanth as protagonist; 40 minutes of live action footage will be shot with the superstar
Expected to be released in: 2008

FILM: *Hanuman Returns*
PRODUCER: PPC and Toonz Animation
COST: Rs 27 crore **USP:** A modern portrayal of Hanuman
Expected to be released in: October 2007



FILM: *Arjun* **PRODUCER:** UTV **COST:** Rs 25 crore
USP: Film based on the mythological hero Arjun but told in a contemporary manner
Expected to be released in: 2008

FILM: *Ek Khiladi Ek Hasina Version 2.0*
PRODUCER: PNC Production **COST:** Rs 25 crore
USP: Live action made into an animation film in collaboration with Florida-based Motion Pixel Corporation
Expected to be released in: 2008



who has been abandoned.

EKEH 2.0 is just one of the five films PNC has plans for. It has signed a five-film deal with Motion Pixel Corporation, a Florida-based animation company which has one of the world's best animation studios, Estudio Flex, in Costa Rica. The exclusive deal between the two firms includes 3D animated, full-length Bollywood feature films with Indian and international actors, songs and item numbers. Says Prithvi Nandy, "Formula films are not working anymore, people want new, challenging stuff. Our animation films will defy norms and will be thrillers with a difference."

With animation becoming the new lingua franca, India's film industry is ready to go global with its mythological characters. Since it allows easy dubbing and more universal characters, the reach of animation is much more than that of Hindi cinema. With children and young adults being the target audience, most studios are looking at a couple of mythological

films. PPC is ready to re-release *Hanuman Returns* this year while UTV is working on a film based on Arjun, the hero of the Mahabharata. But the mother of them all, set for release in 2008, is *Sultan the Warrior*, whose lead character, Rajnikanth, plays a mythical hero. The film has 40 minutes of live action footage with the superstar. All his characteristic mannerisms will be cloned in the movie. Says Siddhartha Jain, head of the animation division at Adlabs, "Animation films should be created with ideas and themes that cannot be done in live action. The budget for *Sultan the Warrior* is Rs 40 crore and it will be a very advanced film dubbed in four languages." For this

project, Adlabs has partnered with Ocher Studios, headed by Rajnikanth's wife Latha.

It's not just film studios that are jumping on to the animation bandwagon. Firms like Toonz and DQ Entertainment, which have been involved in providing back-end technical services to Hollywood studios, are now making films and selling them to big corporates, which are marketing them in India and overseas. Toonz, for instance, has co-produced *Hanuman Returns* with PPC.

"Indian animation shops have come a long way. Films like *Shrek* and *Finding Nemo* could soon be coming out of India," says

P. Jayakumar, CEO, Toonz, which has co-produced the BBC animated series *FreeFonix*. The company is working on a feature film based on the Mahabharata and is also co-producing the TV series *Wolverine* for Marvel Comics. With the Indian film industry zooming in on toons, Bollywood wars will also be fought in animation. ■

Making an animation film costs at least Rs 15-20 crore and takes longer than making a live action movie.

Cash also attempted, with over 10 minutes of animation. The animation sequence was incorporated in such a way that it fitted in with the imagery. For instance, in a sequence in which Suniel Shetty is about to shoot the villain, the first part is in live action but the second part is animated, with the villain's flowing blood being reflected in Shetty's sunglasses.

With the genre catching the imagination of the nation, the coming year will be dominated by animation films. And big production houses don't want to be left behind. Yash Raj Films and Walt Disney are coming together for an animated film based on a dog's life. Titled *Roadside Romeo*, and written and directed by actor Jugal Hansraj, the movie is about a pampered poodle